They Were Always Ready. Someone Just Had to Show up

How a community-led intervention is turning neglected Anganwadis into vibrant preschool spaces in HD Kote

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Deep inside the forests of the Nagarahole Tiger Reserve, past roads that barely qualify as roads, sits a small Anganwadi in the Manimoole Tribal Hamlet. For years, it functioned as little more than a room where children occasionally showed up and left. There was no structured learning, no teaching materials, and no real sense of purpose. No life in the room that should be brimming with children's laughter. The Anganwadi teacher, Seethe, who is also the first woman from the Anemala tribal community ever to become an Anganwadi Teacher, showed up at the Anganwadi every day carrying the weight of a role that she has not been fully prepared to handle.

“Initially, Seethe was not being very regular to her anganwadi, nor was she getting deeply involved in preschool learning. I think it was not so much about her unwillingness to do so, it was more about a lack of awareness.” - Sunayana Chatrapathy, CEO Makkala Jagriti.

Seethe’s story is not unusual in Heggadadevana Kote, commonly known as HD Kote, a backward Taluk in Mysore district of Karnataka state. Across 12 administrative circles. 408

Anganwadi centres are supposed to serve as the first point of formal early learning for children in the age group of 3 to 6. For much of their existence, these centres have remained invisible to the community, undersupervised, underresourced and undervalued by the very communities they were meant to serve.

“It is easy to say that anganwadi teachers don't open the anganwadi on time. But what is the reality of these teachers? Why do they not open it on time? Can we understand it and support them in figuring out how they can?

Asks Amrutha Murali, the deputy director of Early Childhood Care and Education at Makkala Jagriti.

“*When you work from that lens, and then offer solutions, I feel a much deeper understanding develops, and the teacher begins to trust you.”*

This is the problem, Makkala Jagriti, a Bangalore-based non-profit organisation working with children and youth in the age group of 3 to 24 from socio-economically disadvantaged backgrounds, decided to take on. The project, which took off in partnership with HCL Foundation, is one of the significant interventions in early childhood education happening in Karnataka today. With this partnership, Makkala Jagriti has managed to bring quality preschool education to unreachable pockets of tribal HD Kote, which had been left behind.



“For the spirit of Makkala Jagriti, working with the community is not so much about prescribing or simply transferring knowledge and skills, but about truly making them partners in this journey. We are facilitators and enablers, helping them discover their role, the importance of that role, and feel empowered that they can transform their community, influence their community, and take their community forward. “ - Sunayana Chatrapathy

HD Kote has a larger population of families from the Scheduled Tribes (ST), and the numbers reflect a familiar inequality. Nationally, only 13.1% of ST Children attend pre-primary education, which is a stark reminder of the access gap (Choudhury, Joshy & Kumar, 2023). And even where anganwadis exist, the quality is often uneven. For tribal children in particular, the opportunity to experience quality preschool learning is nearly nonexistent. Across HD Kote’s 408 Anganwadi centres, the promise of early education existed largely on paper with no real force to bring it to life.



Jyothi, an Anganwadi teacher from H D Kote, reveals what the gap looked like from inside.

“We used to conduct activities before as well. We had government training to do this. But most of the time, we didn't know why exactly certain activities were done. The reason behind each activity came after the capacity building sessions we received at the Makkala Jagrity trainings.” Jyothi - Anganwadi Teacher

This is the gap Makkala Jagriti set out to close. The Early Childhood Care and Education (ECCE) Team entered HD Kote as collaborators, sitting with teachers, understanding their daily realities and building trust before building anything else. They worked alongside Anganwadi teachers and parents, recognising that lasting change depends on the people who show up to it every day.



“Trust takes time to build. We see it happen very gradually and organically, and not necessarily at the first attempt. It is the continuous showing up for that teacher, day in and day out, that invariably makes them see you as part of the system and not as an outsider” - Amrutha Murali

Makkala Jagriti upholds an approach that strengthens the awareness and involvement of every stakeholder around the child. With teachers and helpers, the organisation introduced regular one-hour preschool sessions, with structured weekly timetables, turning previously unorganised centres into purposeful spaces that support children’s socioemotional, cognitive, physical, and language development. Alongside this, multiple capacity-building sessions were conducted for the Anganwadi Teachers and helpers, equipping them with the knowledge and skills to facilitate early childhood learning. The training sessions introduced creative teaching methodologies, strengthened collaboration, and repositioned helpers as active co-educators rather than passive support staff.



Learning and activity materials were distributed to 60% Anganwadi centres, enabling teachers to create sustainable, locally relevant teaching and learning materials that made classrooms more interactive and resource-rich. To keep the momentum alive, WhatsApp groups were introduced to teachers as well as parents, functioning as a steady channel for sharing ECCE activities, updates, and learning videos. Over time, well-developed centres demonstrated what a model anganwadi could look like, giving teachers, parents and the community a vision to work towards.

An annual celebration called Anganwadi Habba brings together teachers, parents, grandparents and the wider community across the circles to celebrate early childhood education. Families gather with curiosity and excitement, watching their children play with learning materials, while teachers, now confident and rooted in purpose, explain the why behind every activity. More than a celebration, the Habba becomes a symbol of what this intervention has made possible.



The urge to know more, learn, and also provide the best for their children was always there in the community. All they needed was someone to walk them through it. Makkala Jagriti did not begin the intervention thinking that they would rope in the community to lead the transformation. Most of it happened organically because of the absence of a strong system to support it. And the genuine involvement of the parents in their kid's growth.



Today Seethe's Anganwadi in Manimoole is a different place. The room was once silent, but now has a vibrant learning environment, purpose and the laughter of children playing and learning. Across HD Kote, the intervention has reached 60% of parents, increased enrolment and begun influencing neighbouring Taluks in Mysore district. The most significant shift is the new awareness and purpose in teachers who once conducted the activity without knowing why. And the beauty lies in every individual in the community, and in the conviction they have in bringing the best their child deserves. In every step, they held closer to the idea of change and embraced it when it happened.

Reference:

Choudhury, P.K., Joshi, R., & Kumar, A. (2023). Regional and socioeconomic inequalities in access to pre-primary education in India: evidence from a recent household survey. International Journal of Child Care and Education Policy, 17(13). https://doi.org/10.1186/s40723-023-00117-4